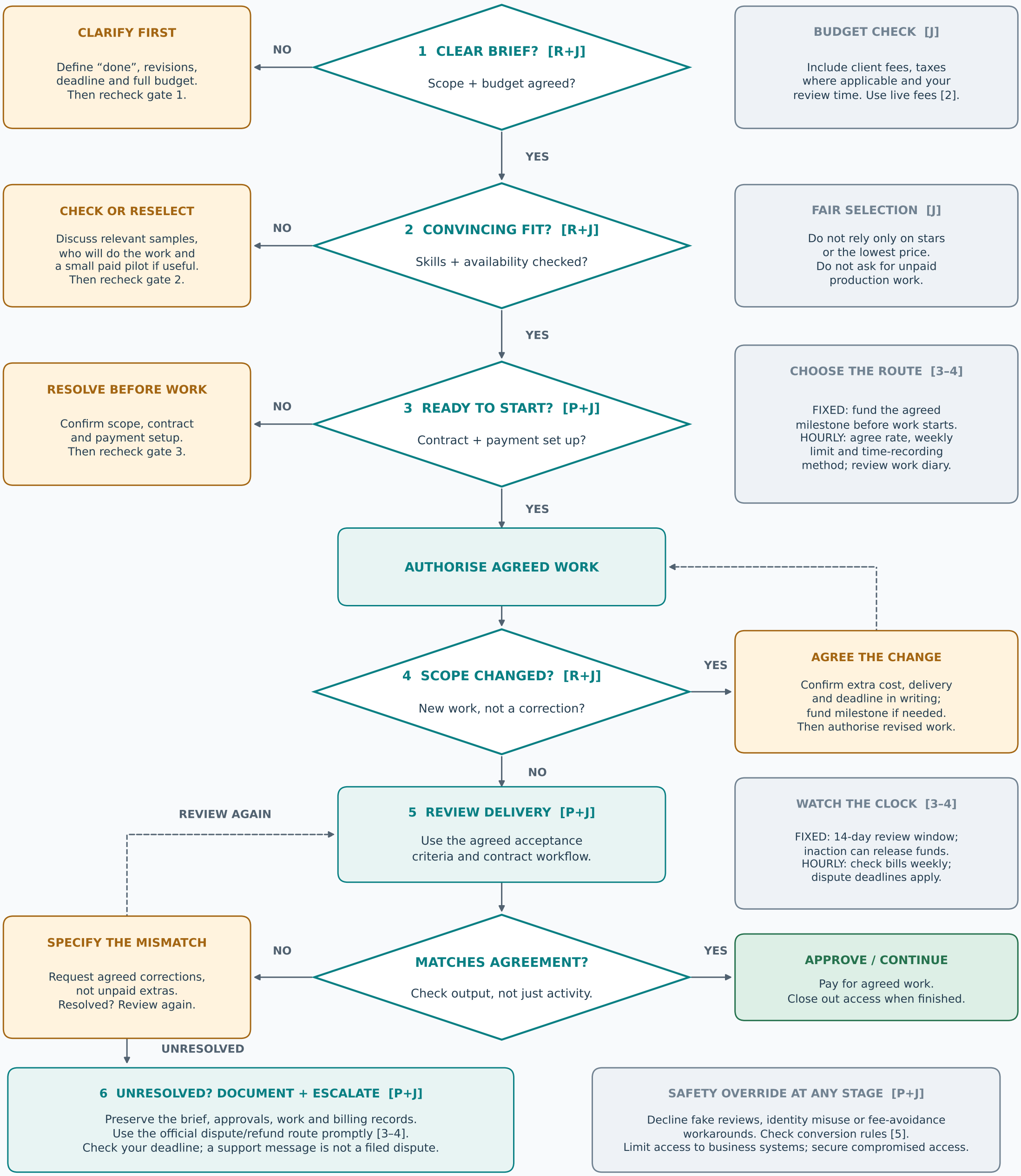
UPWORK / CLIENT DECISION FLOWCHART

Hire clearly. Review fairly.

EXPERT REVIEW COPY v0.1 • NOT APPROVED FOR DISTRIBUTION • 28 October 2026



HOW TO READ THE EVIDENCE

R = paper-reported; LOW confidence for generalising. P = stated platform rule, not proof of fair outcomes.

J = practical judgement, not tested by the paper. These are plain-language labels, not formal GRADE ratings.

LIMITS: The paper reports 218 studies/reports, 495 perspectives and 50 enforcement sources; overlap is unclear.
The PDF lacks a full auditable source inventory and extraction dataset. No validated hiring algorithm or risk estimate.
Supplied PDF: 15 July 2024; task metadata: 2026. Policy checks: 28 October 2026, search-indexed official text only;
direct pages blocked (403). Recheck live terms, exceptions and deadlines. No guarantee of quality or a refund.

[1] Leocadio, Navigating Upwork, pp. 2–4, 22–24, 34–36. https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6031034
[2] Upwork: Client Marketplace Fee. https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/4660220468499
[3] Upwork: Fixed-price review. https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/17974824831507
[4] Upwork: Hourly disputes. https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/17976540792467
[5] Upwork: Off-platform payments. https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/360048105134

EXPERT SIGN-OFF: Author/methods + platform-policy adviser + client/freelancer usability review. Not legal advice; not Upwork-endorsed.

Expert review: evidence and policy audit

Purpose: review the client-facing flowchart, not endorse the paper or certify legal compliance. All items below are OPEN; this packet prepares a review and does not claim one has occurred.

Version under review: client flowchart v0.1, 28 October 2026. Source: Leocadio, Navigating Upwork, DOI 10.2139/ssrn.6031034. The PDF is dated 15 July 2024; task metadata says 2026. Confirm the citation before release.

Reviewer: _____ Role/organisation: _____ Date: _____

For each row, record Accept / Revise / Unable to verify, the supporting source and access date, and exact replacement wording if needed. Open release blockers must be resolved or the affected claim removed.

ID / owner	Target and release-blocking check	Decision / evidence / correction
R1 — Author / methods	Evidence footer: verify 218 studies/reports, 495 perspectives and 50 enforcement sources (paper pp. 2–4); explain overlap. Supply included-source inventory, search/extraction details and bias assessment, or retain the low-confidence caveat. Confirm 2024/2026 version.	OPEN Decision: _____ Source/date: _____ Change: _____
R2 — Policy adviser	Gate 1: verify client fees against source [2] and the relevant plan/account. Check taxes, initiation fees and exceptions. Keep “use live fees”; do not import historical freelancer fee tiers.	OPEN Decision: _____ Source/date: _____ Change: _____
R3 — Policy adviser	Gate 3: verify active-contract and milestone funding workflow; confirm hourly rate, weekly-limit and time-recording guidance. Ensure no box implies guaranteed quality, payment recovery or a refund. Sources [3–4].	OPEN Decision: _____ Source/date: _____ Change: _____
R4 — Policy adviser	Watch the clock: verify the 14-day fixed-price window, trigger, change-request/resubmission effects and automatic-release exceptions. Check the client contract workflow. Source [3].	OPEN Decision: _____ Source/date: _____ Change: _____
R5 — Policy adviser	Gate 6: verify hourly dispute filing deadline, timezone, eligible grounds and filing method. Distinguish formal disputes from support messages and refund requests. Review fixed-price escalation too. Sources [3–4].	OPEN Decision: _____ Source/date: _____ Change: _____
R6 — Policy / legal adviser	Safety override: verify conversion requirements, permitted exceptions and off-platform restrictions [5]. Check access/privacy advice and local legal implications; avoid implying an exception or guaranteed remedy.	OPEN Decision: _____ Source/date: _____ Change: _____

Verification limitation: earlier checks used search-indexed official text; direct official-page retrieval returned HTTP 403. No new live-policy verification or external expert approval was completed for this packet.

Usability, issue log and release decision

R = paper-reported, low confidence for generalising. P = stated platform rule, not independent proof of fairness. J = practical judgement, not tested by the paper. These labels are not formal GRADE ratings.

Client and freelancer reviewers: walk through (a) an unfunded milestone, (b) an extra deliverable beyond scope, (c) defective work against the original brief, and (d) disputed hourly time near a deadline. Record the route taken and whether the next action is clear.

R7 — Flow and fairness: Can a reviewer distinguish new scope from an agreed correction? Does the return arrow lead to the right gate? Does any correction loop risk missing a dispute deadline? Are “continue” and access close-out clear? Confirm protection against unpaid extras and feedback pressure.

R8 — Accessibility: Check at intended print size and on a phone; confirm text size, contrast, arrow direction and meaning without colour. The chart is a large-format graphic, not a validated hiring instrument. Add an accessible text companion if needed; the existing client guide provides the full narrative.

Issue / gate	Proposed change + source/date	Owner / resolution
R7 / usability: _____	_____ _____	Owner: _____ Resolved/date: _____
R8 / accessibility: _____	_____ _____	Owner: _____ Resolved/date: _____
Other: _____	_____ _____	Owner: _____ Resolved/date: _____

Sign-off — complete after corrections

Each reviewer approves only their scope. “Revise” is not permission to distribute. Final release requires closed blockers, a checked final version and a named release owner.

Review scope	Name / signature / date	Decision
Author / methods	_____	Accept / Revise / Cannot verify
Platform policy / legal	_____	Accept / Revise / Cannot verify
Client usability	_____	Accept / Revise / Cannot verify
Freelancer fairness / usability	_____	Accept / Revise / Cannot verify

Final disposition: HOLD / APPROVE FOR DEFINED USE / DO NOT USE. Release owner: _____

Approved version/date: _____ Audience/jurisdiction/format: _____

Next policy recheck: _____ Outstanding limitations to retain: _____

Source index (same numbering as chart): [1] https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6031034; [2] https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/4660220468499; [3] https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/17974824831507; [4] https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/17976540792467; [5] https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/360048105134

Prepared for expert review only. No expert has signed this copy. Not legal advice; not endorsed by Upwork.